

MARCH 10, 2026

THE WAR THAT WAS ALWAYS COMING

How four decades of fury, failed diplomacy, and nuclear fear finally ignited the conflict the world spent years dreading and what it means for all of us.

Day 10 Active Conflict	1,300+ Killed in Iran	47 yrs of US–Iran hostility	\$115+ per barrel oil
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◆ INTRODUCTION ◆

Nobody who has watched the Middle East for the past twenty years should claim to be surprised. The war between the United States, Israel, and Iran that began on February 28, 2026 was not an accident, not a miscalculation, not a crisis that spun out of control. It was, in many ways, a choice — made deliberately, after every other option had been exhausted or rejected.

What makes it historic isn't just the scale of the destruction. It's how long it took to get here, and how many times, over how many decades, it almost happened before it finally did. To understand why Iranian cities are on fire today, you have to go back — not just to last week's failed nuclear talks in Oman, but all the way back to 1979, to the moment a revolution tore apart not just a country but a relationship between two nations that has never, in nearly half a century, been properly repaired.

◆ CHAPTER ONE ◆

The Long Fuse: 1979 to Now

How a revolution broke a relationship that was never fixed

When the Shah fell in January 1979 and Ayatollah Khomeini flew back from exile to a roaring crowd of millions, the world witnessed something genuinely new: a modern Islamic theocracy replacing a secular, Western-aligned monarchy almost overnight. For ordinary Iranians, it felt like liberation. For Washington — which had bankrolled and backed the Shah for decades — it was a humiliation and a strategic catastrophe.

Then came November 4th, 1979. A group of Iranian students stormed the US Embassy in Tehran and took 52 Americans hostage. They would hold them for 444 days. The images burned

themselves into American consciousness. That was 47 years ago. The United States has not had an ambassador in Tehran since. When two nations haven't spoken properly for nearly half a century, the ground for war is always being quietly tilled.

What followed was a pattern that would repeat itself again and again: escalation, near-confrontation, a brief cooling, then escalation again. Iran built what its military called a 'ring of fire' around Israel — funding Hezbollah in Lebanon, Hamas in Gaza, backing the Houthis in Yemen, and cultivating Shia militias in Iraq and Syria. The United States responded with waves of sanctions that, by 2025, had reduced the Iranian rial to near worthlessness.



Fig. 1 — US–Iran escalation severity score, 2001–2026. Score of 10 = open warfare.

◆ CHAPTER TWO ◆

The Nuclear Question That Swallowed Everything

How a 70-year-old program became the defining issue of a generation

In 2015, after years of painstaking negotiations, the Obama administration pulled off something remarkable: a deal. The JCPOA — the Iran nuclear deal — capped uranium enrichment, reduced stockpiles, and allowed intrusive inspections. In exchange, sanctions would be lifted and Iran's economy would get the oxygen it desperately needed. It wasn't perfect. But it worked.

Then Donald Trump won the 2016 election. He called the deal 'the worst deal ever made.' In May 2018, he withdrew the United States unilaterally and reimposed sweeping sanctions. His team called it 'maximum pressure.' The deal was dead. And with the deal dead, Iran had no reason to honour its limits.

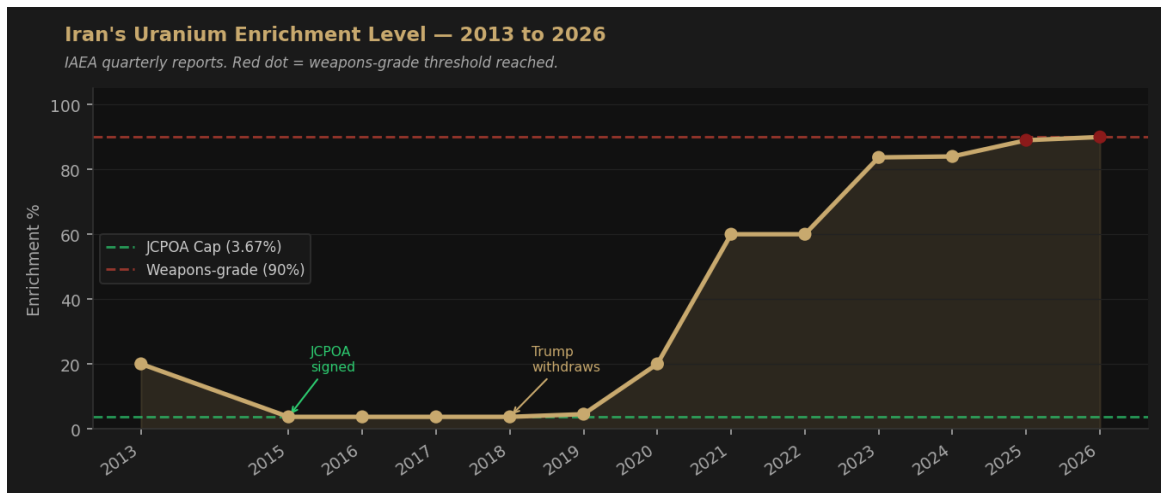


Fig. 2 — Iran uranium enrichment level (% purity), 2013–2026. Weapons-grade threshold $\approx$ 90%.

By 2023, Iran was enriching uranium to 83.7% purity — just a short technical step from the 90% needed for a weapon. By late 2024, the IAEA reported an unprecedented stockpile. By early 2026, intelligence agencies were warning that the gap between 'enough material' and 'an actual bomb' had narrowed to months, not years.

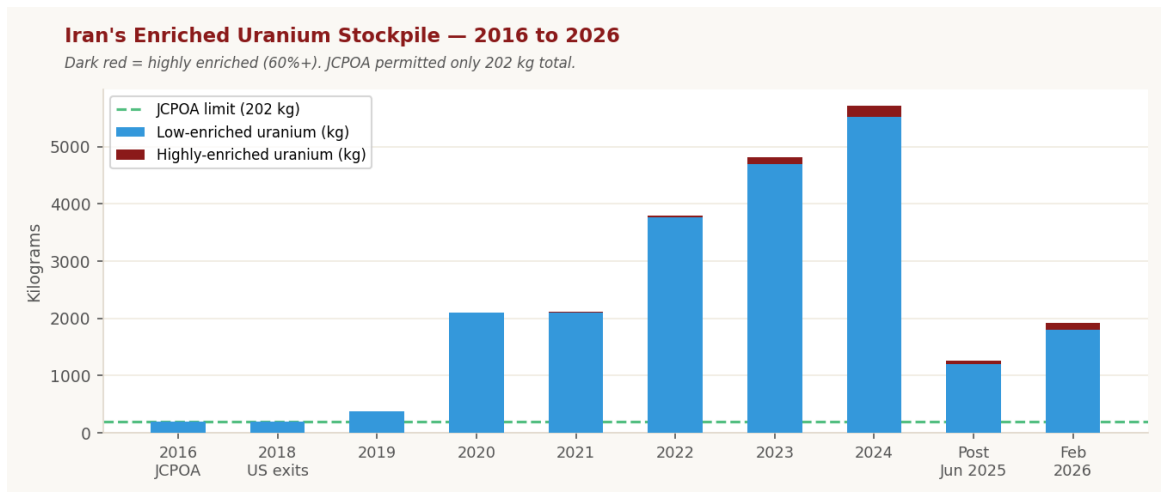


Fig. 3 — Iran enriched uranium stockpile (kg). JCPOA permitted only 202 kg total. Red = highly enriched.

"America cannot sit and watch while Iran builds the bomb. That's not a threat. That's a promise."

— President Donald Trump, State of the Union Address, March 4, 2026

From October 7th to Open War

The chain of events that dismantled Iran's deterrence — and removed its last buffer

October 7, 2023 changed everything. The Hamas massacre of 1,200 Israelis set off a war that, over the next two and a half years, would systematically demolish the architecture Iran had spent decades and billions of dollars constructing. Hezbollah with 150,000 rockets and the most powerful non-state military force in the world was gutted by Israel in late 2024. Hamas was obliterated. The Houthis were degraded. The Shia militias in Iraq were struck repeatedly.

Think of it from Iran's strategic perspective. For years, Tehran's answer to the Israeli military threat was 'forward deterrence' the ability to threaten Israel from multiple directions simultaneously using proxies. If Israel struck Iran, Lebanon would rain rockets. Gaza would erupt. Iraq would fire missiles. By early 2026, that network was gone, or a shadow of itself.

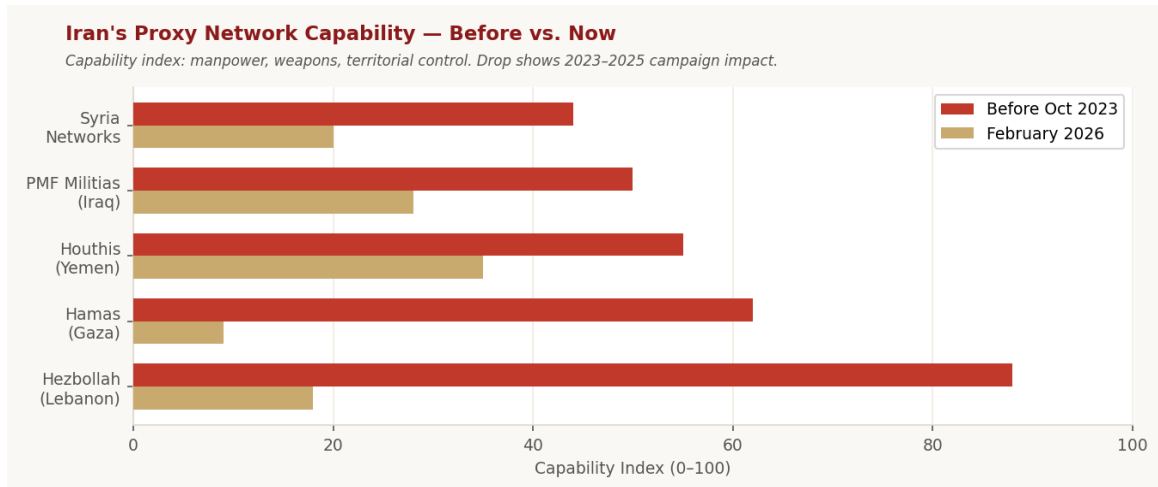


Fig. 4 — Iran proxy network capability before October 2023 vs. February 2026. Dramatic degradation across all groups.

In June 2025, Israel launched a twelve day air campaign that dismantled Iran's air defence systems. US B-2 bombers dropped bunker busting bombs on Fordow an underground nuclear facility previously considered impregnable. Iran was exposed in a way it hadn't been since the revolution. And it was in that exposed, weakened, economically ravaged state that its people rose up.

TIMELINE: THE ROAD TO WAR

KEY EVENTS

- Oct 2023 — Hamas attacks Israel, killing 1,200. Iran as primary sponsor comes under direct focus.
- Apr–Oct 2024 — First direct Iran–Israel military exchanges. Israel penetrates Iranian air defences.
- Late 2024 — Hezbollah dismantled by Israel. Iran's most powerful proxy is neutralized.

- Jun 2025 — The Twelve-Day War. US B-2 bombers strike Fordow. Iran's air defences destroyed.
- Dec 2025–Feb 2026 — Iran's mass uprising. IRGC kills estimated 30,000–43,000 protesters.
- Feb 6, 2026 — Last-chance nuclear talks in Oman collapse. Iran rejects complete dismantlement.
- Feb 28, 2026 — War begins. US & Israel strike Iran. Supreme Leader Khamenei killed.

◆ CHAPTER FOUR ◆

The People Paying the Price

What the war has cost in blood, money, and human suffering

It is easy, when writing about nuclear thresholds and proxy networks and air defence systems, to lose sight of the people. There are real human beings inside every one of these statistics. In December 2025, as Iran's economy collapsed and the rial became almost worthless, a mother in Tehran was choosing between buying insulin for her diabetic son and paying rent. Young men and women poured into the streets not because they had been organized by a political party, but because they had simply, finally, had enough. And the government shot them.

The Iranian government's official death toll from the 2025–26 protests is around 3,000. Human rights organizations believe the real number is somewhere between 30,000 and 43,000. The internet was blacked out. Journalists were arrested. We may never know the true number.

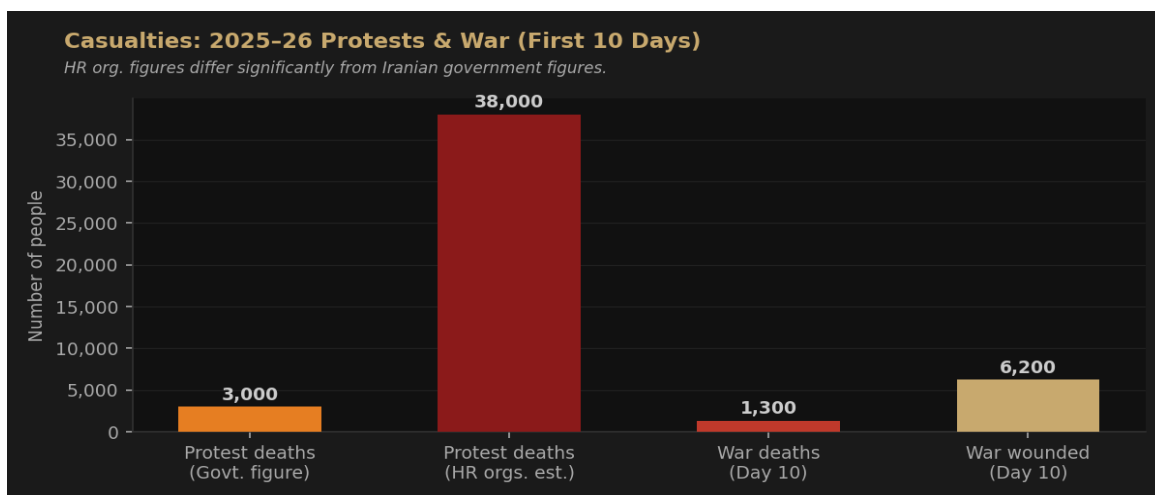


Fig. 5 — Casualties: 2025–26 protests and first 10 days of war. Government figures vs. human rights org. estimates.

Then came the bombs on February 28th. The US and Israel say they targeted military and nuclear infrastructure. Iran says more than 1,300 civilians have been killed in the first ten days, with over 6,000 wounded. Hospitals in Tehran, Isfahan, and Shiraz are overwhelmed. A generation of Iranian scientists and engineers — many with nothing to do with their government's nuclear ambitions — have died or fled.

Iran's Economic Collapse: Key Indicators (2018-2026)

Sanctions reimposed in 2018 after Trump JCPOA withdrawal.

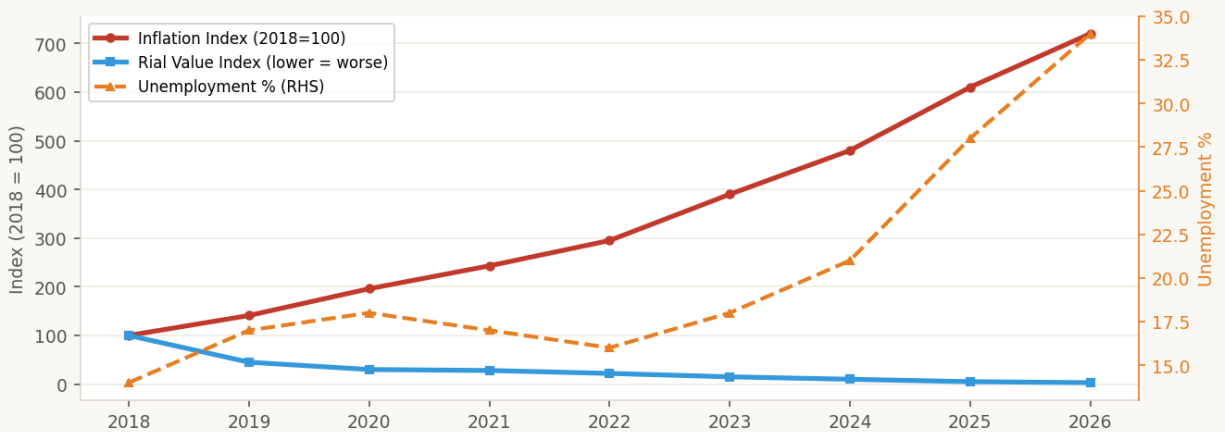


Fig. 6 — Iran's economic collapse: inflation, rial value, and unemployment 2018–2026. US sanctions reimposed in 2018.

◆ CHAPTER FIVE ◆

How This War is Shaking the World

From petrol pumps in Pune to parliaments in Paris — the global aftershocks

Here is the thing about the Middle East that people in quieter corners of the world sometimes forget: the global economy runs on oil, and oil runs through the Persian Gulf. Roughly 20% of all the world's petroleum passes through the Strait of Hormuz — a narrow bottleneck of water, at its narrowest just 21 miles wide. On day one of the war, Iran closed it. They laid mines. They deployed fast attack boats.

The effect on global energy markets was immediate and violent. Oil prices surged past \$115 a barrel in the first week. Petrol prices spiked across Europe, Asia, and Africa. Shipping insurance rates for the Persian Gulf became essentially prohibitive. India, which imports roughly 40% of its oil from the Gulf, went on emergency alert. China was furious.

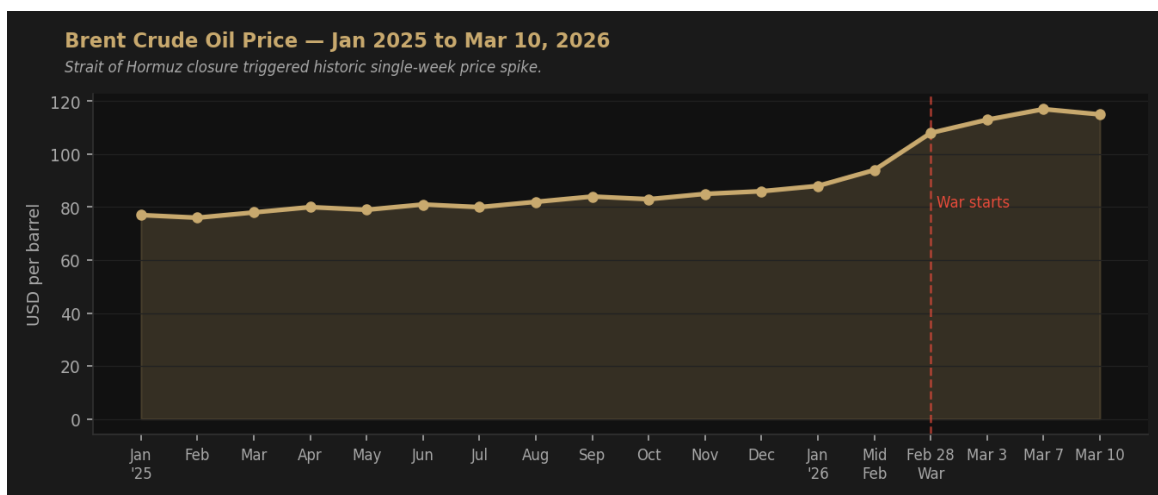


Fig. 7 — Brent crude oil price, Jan 2025 to Mar 10, 2026. War declaration caused single week spike of ~35%.

It isn't just energy. The war has sent shockwaves through global financial markets. Gold hit record highs as investors fled to safety. Stock markets in Europe and Asia fell sharply. The IMF has already issued emergency warnings about the risk of a global recession if the Strait of Hormuz remains closed beyond three to four weeks.

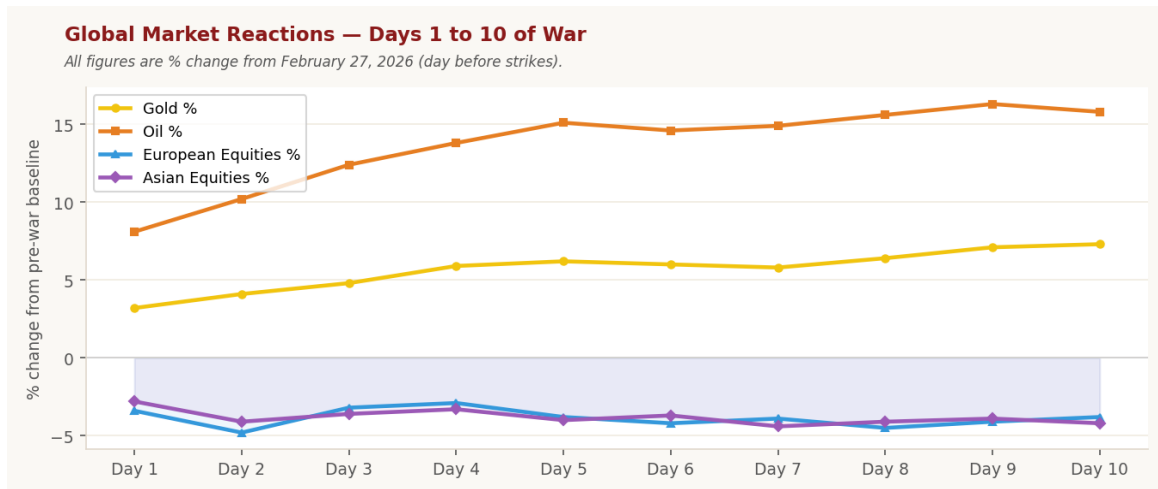


Fig. 8 — Global market reactions, Days 1–10 of war. Oil and gold surge; European and Asian equities decline sharply.

The Geopolitical Fault Lines

Russia and China are watching carefully and neither is happy. Russia has strategic and economic ties to Iran and has been supplying it with advanced weapons. China signed a 25 year partnership agreement with Iran in 2021, imports significant amounts of Iranian oil, and has deep investment interests in the country. Both countries condemned the strikes at the UN Security Council and are exploring responses short of direct confrontation with the United States.

Europe is split. The UK, France, and Germany acknowledged that Iran had violated the nuclear deal and that its program posed a genuine threat, but stopped short of endorsing military action. Spain flatly refused to participate. The UN Secretary General called for an immediate ceasefire and declared the strikes a potential violation of international law.

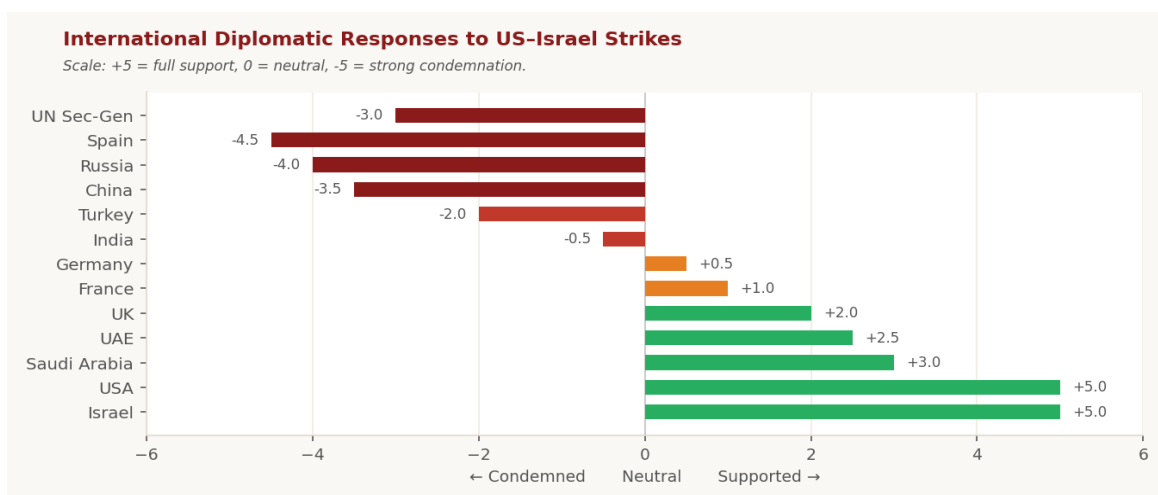


Fig. 9 — International diplomatic positions on US–Israel strikes. Scale: +5 = full support, -5 = strong condemnation.

For countries across the Global South — Africa, Southeast Asia, Latin America — there is a weary familiarity to this moment. A powerful Western nation, backed by its closest ally, has launched strikes on a developing country without UN authorization. Whatever one thinks of Iran's government, the pattern is one they have seen before.

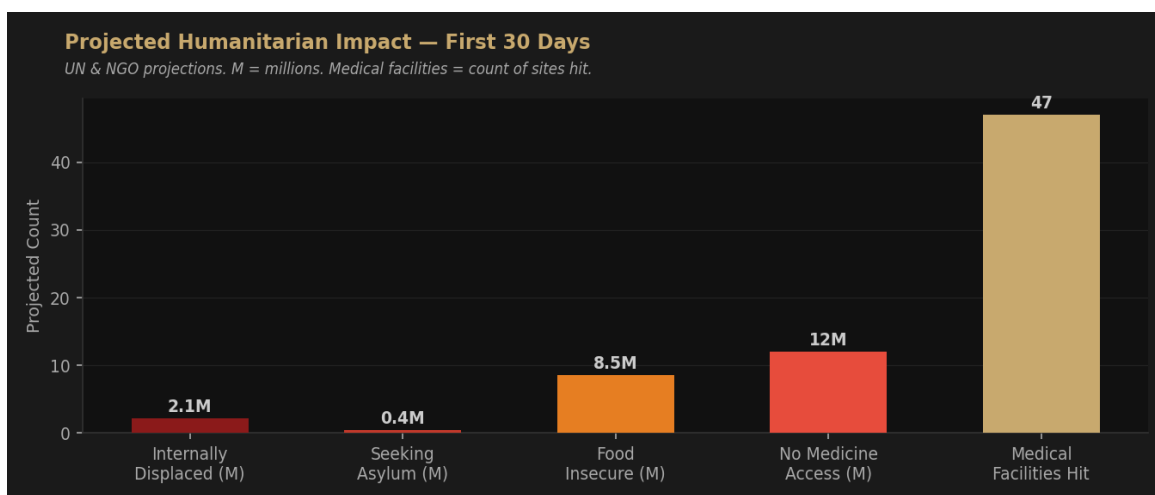


Fig. 10 — Projected humanitarian impact, first 30 days. UNHCR, WFP and WHO projections as of March 2026.

◆ CHAPTER SIX ◆

What Comes Next — and What We Don't Know

The war is ten days old. The hardest questions haven't been answered yet.

On day ten of the war, Supreme Leader Khamenei is dead. The IRGC — Iran's most powerful military and political institution — is fractured but not destroyed. The nuclear program has been set back, but a concealed facility survived the strikes. The protests that were rocking Iran before the bombs fell have quieted — not because Iranians have rallied around the regime, but because people don't march in the streets when the bombs are falling.

President Trump has said the war could last four to five weeks. He has explicitly linked American war aims to regime change — to giving the Iranian people the chance to 'take their destiny into their own hands.' That's a much larger undertaking than destroying a nuclear facility. History has a dismal record when it comes to wars of regime change. Afghanistan. Iraq. Libya. The removal of a government is the easy part compared to what comes after.

"We did not start this. But we will finish it — for the Iranian people, for our Israeli friends, and for a world that cannot live under nuclear blackmail."

— US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, March 3, 2026

The Iranians, for their part, have shown that even in this weakened, battered state, they still have the capacity to hurt people. Their missile and drone barrages struck Gulf states, American bases,

and threatened Israeli cities. They closed the Strait of Hormuz. A cornered government with nothing left to lose and a 47 year grudge is not an opponent that simply folds.

The fuse that was lit in 1979 has burned for 47 years. The explosion, when it came, was exactly as loud as everyone feared. What emerges from the smoke — for Iran, for the region, for the world — is the question that history will spend years trying to answer.

Sources: IAEA, IMF, World Bank, IISS, Bloomberg, Reuters, UN Human Rights Office, Amnesty International, RAND Corporation, Council on Foreign Relations. Events described reflect the situation as of March 10, 2026. The conflict is ongoing.